



accounting for her highly misleading No. 52 ranking. The most relevant stat, though, is her excellent 7-5 career record against top-10 opponents at Grand Slam events.

While Pegula called reaching the final 'a childhood dream', Sabalenka hoped it wouldn't be a nightmare repetition of the final a year ago. To ensure she wouldn't have to listen to the cheering crowd — mostly for

Pegula — when they entered the court, Sabalenka kept her earphones on.

"She looks to overpower opponents," said Nick Kyrgios, who recently became an *ESPN* analyst. "She's a heavy favourite." Another *ESPN* analyst, Rennae Stubbs, who was trying to encourage Pegula's fans, said, "The crowd could be a difference-maker."

Smart move: Pegula made six Grand Slam quarterfinals from 2021-23 and lost them all. After splitting with her longtime coach, she hired Mark Merklein and Mark Knowles, a former doubles No. 1. The gamble paid off. On the summer hard-court circuit, she won the Toronto tournament and made the Cincinnati final. AFP

As rain pelted the closed roof over Arthur Ashe Stadium, the indoor conditions favoured the hard-hitting Sabalenka. IBM Match Insights made the Belarus Basher a 60 per cent favourite.

The fluctuating final had five service breaks in the opening set alone. When the American lost her serve for the second time to trail 4-2, she complained about her string tension — a detail that should have been dealt with before the match. "If she wants to win Majors, she has to add more power to her game," advised Evert after Sabalenka fired a 119-mph ace to go ahead, 5-2.

Pegula fought back to convert her second break point to slice the lead to 5-4. Raising her arms to encourage even more crowd support, Pegula increasingly fed off the energy of the boisterous fans.

It wasn't quite enough to turn the tide, though. Even when Sabalenka double-faulted to give her a break point for 5-all, 30-40 — and banged her racket on the hard court four times — Pegula couldn't capitalise. Down 6-5, she staved off three set points before Sabalenka, flashing her touch, feathered a nifty drop shot Pegula couldn't handle to take the first set, 7-5.

"Sabalenka had a meltdown in last year's final against Coco," Evert said. "That won't happen this year. She's learned her lesson."

That prediction looked good. When the Belarusian won 12 of the next 14 points to race ahead 3-0, she made the classic mistake of being overconfident, later admitting she thought Pegula would give up.